PIONEER · EDITION 003

Beyond the Surface

Vision 2040 | Building for Sustainability in the Frontier

July 2026 · Featuring Rev. Matt Buckley

The era of the deep. A building is only as strong as the ground it sits upon. The National Director explains how pioneers will be equipped and supported, and Rev. Matt Buckley shares nearly four decades of pioneering in Botswana.

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FROM THE VISIONNAIRE'S DESK

A Conversation with the National Director, Part III

Having laid the foundation of Vision 2040 and its mandate, the National Director now sheds light on how pioneers will be equipped, mentored, and supported — and the vital role of partners, churches, and professionals.

Rev. Tokunbo Adejuwon — National Director, Rhema Bible Training Centre Nigeria

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How does Vision 2040 intend to support and protect pioneers once they are in the field?

If we tell people, "We'll fund you, we'll give you the money, we'll send you people, we'll raise your team for you," then we're not being truthful. So let's say it upfront — we won't do all of that. Because if we do, we are not giving people the opportunity to grow.

So what will we do? We will help them learn how to raise finances. We will help them learn how to build a team. We want people to function in the spirit of faith. Because people reproduce after their parents — not just what you teach, but also what you are. So it is what you are that you will raise.

There will be a lot of training. There will be a lot of counsel given. Could there be times when support may be needed, whether financial or in terms of resources? Yes, that is possible. But that is not the foundation. We want people to be financially independent and to be able to raise their own teams. That said, if support is needed, we will be there.

But fundamentally, our approach is this: we will train them, we will empower them, we will equip them, we will mentor them. We will not leave them out in the cold. We will maintain communication with them. We will pray for them. We will provide guidance, encouragement, and godly counsel. And if there are moments where they need help with specific things, we will step in where necessary.

But the heart of it is this — we want people who will go with this mindset: "Pray for me. Believe in me. Stay connected with me — I'm going." And we will be there with them. Support may come in different forms, financially if needed, with human resources if needed, but consistently through prayer, counsel, encouragement, and mentorship. We will be there for them.

For partners and professionals, is there a place for those who cannot physically relocate?

Definitely. There may be someone who is not ready to relocate but can go on short-term mission trips. They can help raise a team in a location, go there for a period, and work with people on the ground.

Are there going to be people who will visit, encourage, and support? Of course. Are there going to be people who partner financially with those on the field? Yes. Are there going to be people who raise prayer support? Yes. Are there going to be people who say, “As you are there, let me handle things on this side. Let me help with your home base. Let me support your family”? Yes.

There will also be churches that get involved — churches that say, “We believe in what Rhema is doing. We are already looking for missionaries to support, and now we have people who share our doctrine and conviction that we can stand behind.” There will also be people who may not relocate but can contribute in practical ways, for example during building projects or by providing technical expertise.

So yes, there is a place for everybody. Pioneering does not necessarily mean relocating. There is a role for everyone: those who go, those who support, those who strengthen, and those who supply. And yes, there is also a place for those who relocate — and it is a good place, a great place.

> *Pray for me. Believe in me. Stay connected with me — I’m going.*

> *There is a place for everybody. Pioneering does not necessarily mean relocating.*

PIONEER BLUEPRINT

The Road Less Travelled

A conversation with Rev. Matt Buckley, Director of Rhema Botswana.

Rev. Matt Buckley — Director, Rhema Botswana · Founder, Light of the World Church

> A graduate of Rhema USA (1987), Rev. Matt Buckley and his wife, Kristin, moved to Botswana in October 1989 and have served there ever since. From a roadside encounter with a flat tyre to nearly four decades of ministry, he reflects on residence permits, church planting, team building, family, finances, and the long road that became Rhema Botswana.

Let’s start at the beginning. Why Botswana?

I graduated from Rhema USA in 1987, and my wife graduated the following year. During my time there, I knew God had called me into missions. That conviction had grown from several short-term mission trips I took as a teenager.

A few months after graduation, missionaries serving in Zimbabwe connected with me through Rhema USA. They shared their work with me, and although I told them I would pray about it, I knew almost immediately that this was my next step.

While Kristin was completing her second year at Rhema, I travelled to Africa to help with evangelistic crusades in Zimbabwe. During that trip, Brother Hagin preached from Acts 9 about Saul being told, “Go into the city, and it will be told you what you must do.” The Holy Spirit impressed that Scripture on my heart. I didn’t know the whole plan — I simply knew I was to go.

On our way back from Zimbabwe, we passed through Botswana and had a flat tyre. While I waited by the roadside, God spoke clearly to my heart: “You’ll come back to this place after you get married.” At that point, I hardly knew anything about Botswana. I didn’t know anyone there. But after I returned home, I shared it with Kristin, and she immediately embraced the vision. Less than a year after we were married, in October 1989, we moved to Botswana — and we’ve been here ever since.

When you arrived in Botswana, what did “starting from zero” actually look like?

The very first challenge wasn’t preaching — it was simply finding a way to stay in the country. We arrived without anyone officially hosting us, which immediately created immigration challenges. I remember walking around the immigration headquarters looking for someone who could help. Eventually, I found myself in the office of the chief immigration officer, who kindly tried to advise us, although even he wasn’t sure how we should proceed.

After a real faith journey, we eventually received our residence permits. By November 1991, after nearly two years of travelling back and forth between America and Africa and living out of suitcases, we finally unpacked our belongings and settled into our first home in Francistown. Looking back, securing those residence permits was probably our biggest first hurdle.

How did you build a team when you knew absolutely no one?

That’s probably one of the biggest lessons I’ve learned over the years. Honestly, don’t do it the way we did. In the beginning, our entire team was just Kristin and me. We did everything ourselves because we didn’t yet understand how important it was to intentionally build a team.

Originally, I thought we would start a Bible school. Instead, the Lord directed us to plant a church first. So in 1993, we started Light of the World Church. That church eventually became the place where relationships were built, leaders were raised, and people were trained.

When we launched Light of the World Bible Training Center in 2000, many of those same people became the foundation of the work. Seventeen years later, that Bible school transitioned into Rhema Botswana. Looking back, I tell every pioneer the same thing: don't try to do it alone. Build relationships early. Build a team early. That's one thing I would definitely do differently.

Do you believe planting the church first laid the foundation for the Bible school?

Absolutely. The church helped us become known in the community, develop relationships, and build trust. It became the hub from which everything else grew.

Ministry training naturally begins within the local church. As people were discipled and developed there, opening the Bible school became the next logical step. Eventually, that journey led to Rhema Botswana.

How did you raise support, and what would you say to someone who feels called but doesn't have enough money to begin?

The first thing is to be fully persuaded that this is what God has called you to do. You may not know every step, but you must be convinced of the vision yourself. When you're convinced, God begins to bring people into your life who will partner with that vision.

It's natural to think, who do I know that has a lot of money? Certainly, God uses people with resources, but more importantly, He uses people who connect with the vision. Over the years, I've watched God provide through some of the most unlikely people. Sometimes those you expect to give don't, while those you least expect become major partners.

Large gifts certainly help, but so do the many people who faithfully do what they can. It all adds up. The key is not simply finding people with money — it's communicating the vision. When people connect with the vision, God speaks to their hearts, and the provision follows.

What practical advice would you give someone preparing to pioneer?

In the early days, we did everything ourselves. We were the preachers, the ushers, the greeters, the setup team, the cleanup crew, the transport team — everything. I'd pray for people and then have to

catch them myself if they fell. That's certainly not the ideal way to do it.

Before you establish a church, a Bible school, or any new work, get boots on the ground. Spend time in the place. Meet people. Learn the culture. Discover who is already there. If there are believers in the area, get to know them. They may not all become part of your ministry, but they can provide valuable insight — the trustworthy estate agents, immigration consultants, local leaders, and people who can help you navigate the environment.

Technology makes it easier to begin building relationships from a distance, but eventually, nothing replaces being physically present. Visit the place, meet people face to face, and begin forming relationships. Those relationships often become the foundation upon which everything else is built.

You eventually transitioned into an official Rhema campus. What did that process teach you?

When Rhema began expanding internationally around 1999, we approached them about becoming a campus. At the time, they had expanded rapidly and weren't ready to add more campuses. Rather than becoming discouraged, we simply moved forward with what God had already put in our hearts. We started Light of the World Bible Training Center and taught the same principles we had received at Rhema. Even our student handbook was based on the Rhema USA handbook.

Years later, we paused the Bible school for several years in preparation to relaunch as Rhema Botswana. Looking back, becoming part of the Rhema family was about much more than changing the name on the sign outside the building. It gave us access to an incredible network of leaders, proven systems, resources, and decades of experience.

We could have continued independently, but joining the Rhema family strengthened the work tremendously. We didn't have to figure everything out ourselves because many of those lessons had already been learned by others.

What advice would you give someone called to pioneer, but whose spouse isn't convinced?

Before Kristin and I moved to Africa, we both knew God had called us to missions, but we didn't yet know what that would look like. When I returned from my first trip to Africa, I carefully began sharing what God had put on my heart. I started by saying how much I had enjoyed Africa, then suggested we might go back for a while. Eventually, I told her I believed God wanted us to move there. Her response was simple: "Let's do it." Looking back, I realised God had already been preparing her heart.

That's why I believe agreement is so important. Scripture asks, "Can two walk together unless they agree?" I don't believe we should sacrifice our marriages for the sake of ministry. Marriage comes before ministry. If your spouse isn't ready, look for the areas where you can agree — pray together, support the work financially, or make short-term trips together. Trust God to continue working in both your hearts.

There were seasons when the adjustment was especially difficult for Kristin. Everything, from grocery shopping to understanding the culture, was new. One day, while she was crying before the Lord, asking why she was there, she sensed Him say, "You're not here for yourself. You're here for the people." That changed everything. When you keep the eternal purpose in view, you're able to move beyond temporary challenges.

What would you say to a Rhema graduate wrestling with fear, uncertainty, or feelings of inadequacy?

You already have what it takes. God has placed His Spirit of faith within you. Don't wait until every detail is clear before taking action. Begin with the first step. Pray. Get involved. Connect with others carrying the same vision. Visit the places God has put on your heart. Write down your strategy as you go.

One thing I've learned is that the path often becomes clearer as you start walking. You don't have to see the entire journey before taking the first step. Stay close to people who carry faith, because faith is contagious. Don't isolate yourself from those who believe God for great things. God orders our steps — and He can only direct a person who is willing to move.

EDITOR'S NOTE

Rev. Matt Buckley's journey reminds us that pioneering is rarely about having every answer before you begin. It is about taking the next obedient step, trusting that God will reveal the path as you walk it. From a roadside encounter in Botswana to nearly four decades of ministry, his story is proof that great works often begin with a simple "yes."

> *I didn't know the whole plan — I simply knew I was to go.*

> *The path often becomes clearer as you start walking. You don't have to see the entire journey before taking the first step.*

COUNTRY FOCUS

The Republic of Senegal

To win a nation, you must first know its story.

POPULATION SIZE

~18 Million

Highly urbanised. Dakar is the “Paris of Africa,” a sophisticated hub where the Word must be presented with excellence.

DOMINANT RELIGION

Islam 96% (Sufi Orders)

Deep respect for spiritual authority and tradition. The strategy is dialogue over debate.

CHRISTIAN EXPRESSION

~4% (Roman Catholic)

A respected minority. The Pentecostal structure is young, making this a Tier 1 field for systematic faith training that produces stable local leaders.

LITERACY RATE

~51%

One of the most intellectual climates in Francophone Africa. French is the language of the elite and the classroom.

PRIMARY LANGUAGES

French & Wolof

To win the market, you speak Wolof; to win the academy, you speak French.

YOUTH POPULATION

~60% under 24

A digital generation that is more globally connected than their parents. They are looking for a faith that is practical and modern.

URBAN VS RURAL

Concentrated in Dakar

Rural regions remain underserved. Expansion outside the major cities is one of the greatest opportunities.

BIBLE SCHOOLS

Developing

A massive void for systematic faith teaching. The deepening here happens through long-term relationship building.

DID YOU KNOW?

The Gateway of Teranga

Senegal is known for Teranga, the culture of hospitality. This is the pioneer’s greatest asset. In a land that prizes hospitality, the home-hub or study group model is the most effective way to plant the seed of the Word.

THE 10/40 GAP

Critical frontier. Senegal is the western anchor of the unreached world.

STATE FOCUS

Bauchi State

The Pearl of Tourism.

GEOPOLITICAL ZONE

North-East

Bauchi sits in a region of deep tradition where a value-added, service-first presence opens doors.

POPULATION SIZE

~8.3 Million

A massive, diverse population. While the city is the centre, Bauchi's strength lies in its 20 Local Government Areas, each with a distinct identity.

DOMINANT RELIGION

Islam (Predominant)

A land of deep religious tradition. We win by being a value-added presence in the community.

CHRISTIAN EXPRESSION

Strong Minority (ECWA, COCIN, Catholic, Pentecostal)

A resilient Christian community. The need is for systematic training that moves them from survival mode to impact mode.

LITERACY RATE

~30–35%

High value on oral tradition. Teaching must be translated into the heart language, Hausa, to truly take root.

PRIMARY LANGUAGES

Hausa & Fulfulde

Hausa is the lingua franca. A pioneer who speaks Hausa in Bauchi doesn't just communicate; they belong.

YOUTH POPULATION

~65%

A huge demographic of energetic youth looking for global standards and skills. Rhema's excellence is a major draw.

URBAN VS RURAL

High Rural Concentration

Beyond the metropolis lies the real harvest. The strategy must include mobile hubs that can travel to agrarian communities.

BIBLE SCHOOLS

Scarce / Denominational

A training oasis is needed. We offer the practical how-to of faith that complements existing theological foundations.

PIONEER PRO-TIP

The Yankari Approach

Just as Yankari is a wildlife sanctuary, the Rhema campus in Bauchi must be a sanctuary for the Spirit. In a region that has seen its share of unrest, we lead with the peace of God and the integrity of the Word. We aren't just bringing a curriculum; we are bringing stability.

THE BIBLICAL OG OF PIONEERING

Nehemiah

The builder who refused to wing it — the man who turned a burden into a blueprint.

The King asked, "What is it you want?" Nehemiah said, "Send me… so I can rebuild it." Some pioneers start with passion. Nehemiah started with a burden — and a building plan.

Before the walls were rebuilt, they were first noticed. Before they were noticed, they were first mourned. And before Nehemiah lifted a single stone, he sat down and prayed. He is the bridge between the spiritual burden (Vision 2040) and the physical structure (the new campuses). He proves that pioneering isn't just about prayer; it's about logistics, leadership, and the grit to keep building when people are mocking your zero.

01. Story Time — From Cupbearer to Builder

Nehemiah was not a prophet. Not a priest. Not a military commander. He was a cupbearer to the King of Persia — a high-security, high-prestige job. He was comfortable. Then he heard the report:

> *The wall of Jerusalem is broken down, and its gates are burnt with fire.*
>
> NEHEMIAH 1:3

Most people hear a bad report and complain. Nehemiah heard a bad report and wept, then fasted and asked for a leave of absence. He traded a palace for a pile of rubble. In simple terms, he saw a zero

(the broken walls) and decided it was time for structure.

02. Pioneer Lesson — The Sword & Trowel Method

Nehemiah didn't build in a vacuum. He faced the critics, Sanballat and Tobiah, who mocked the work, saying, "If even a fox climbed up on it, he would break down their wall of stones!" His response? He didn't stop to argue. He armed the builders.

> *Those who built on the wall… with one hand worked at construction, and with the other held a weapon.*
>
> NEHEMIAH 4:17

03. Modern Mirror — Build While Holding the Word

In Vision 2040, we are Nehemiah-style pioneers. We build the structure (the campuses) while holding the sword (the Word of Faith). We don't wait for the opposition to stop before we start; we build right in the middle of the rubble of the mission field.

MYTH VS FACT

Myth: Nehemiah was a priest or a professional builder. Fact: He was a civil servant — a layman with a heart for God's city. This proves Vision 2040 isn't just for full-time ministers; it is for professionals, administrators, and planners who can build the structure for the Word to flourish. Myth: The wall took decades to build. Fact: It took 52 days. When the right people align with a God-given structure, time collapses.

THE "NEXT TO HIM" STRATEGY

In Nehemiah 3, the phrase "next to him" is repeated over 20 times. Nehemiah didn't build the wall alone; he assigned families to build the section directly in front of their own houses. This is the Rhema model. We don't ask one person to win Nigeria. We ask the graduate in Sokoto to build the hub in Sokoto, and the professional in Bayelsa to build the hub in Bayelsa. When everyone builds the section in front of them, the wall of the national structure is completed.

> *Nehemiah didn't just have a vision; he had a project management plan.*

YOUR NEXT STEP

Find Your Place in the Vision

Vision 2040 is not a project for a few people — it is a mission for all of us.

> Whether God is calling you to pioneer, support those on the field, or help prepare the way for future campuses, there is a place for you in this vision. Here are three practical ways to get involved today.

01 · JOIN THE VISION

Expression of Interest

If you wish to volunteer, serve on an expansion team, support our ongoing initiatives, or explore contribution opportunities for Vision 2040, we welcome your outreach. Complete the Expression of Interest form to become a pioneer.

02 · RECOMMEND A LOCATION

Contact & City Recommendation

Do you know of a city, town, community, church, or ministry that could host a future Rhema campus? Your recommendation could play a vital role in our expansion efforts. Submit a campus recommendation and help us map the frontier.

03 · PARTNER & GIVE

Fuel the Frontier

Every pioneer needs those who supply. Partner financially, raise prayer support, or stand behind a campus as it is planted. When people connect with the vision, God speaks to their hearts, and the provision follows.

Every great work begins with a single step. Take yours today.